

# Hell Is Not Eternal: Only God Is Eternal

## A Biblical and Greek Study of *Aiōn*, *Aiōnios*, Divine Judgment, and the Destiny of Evil

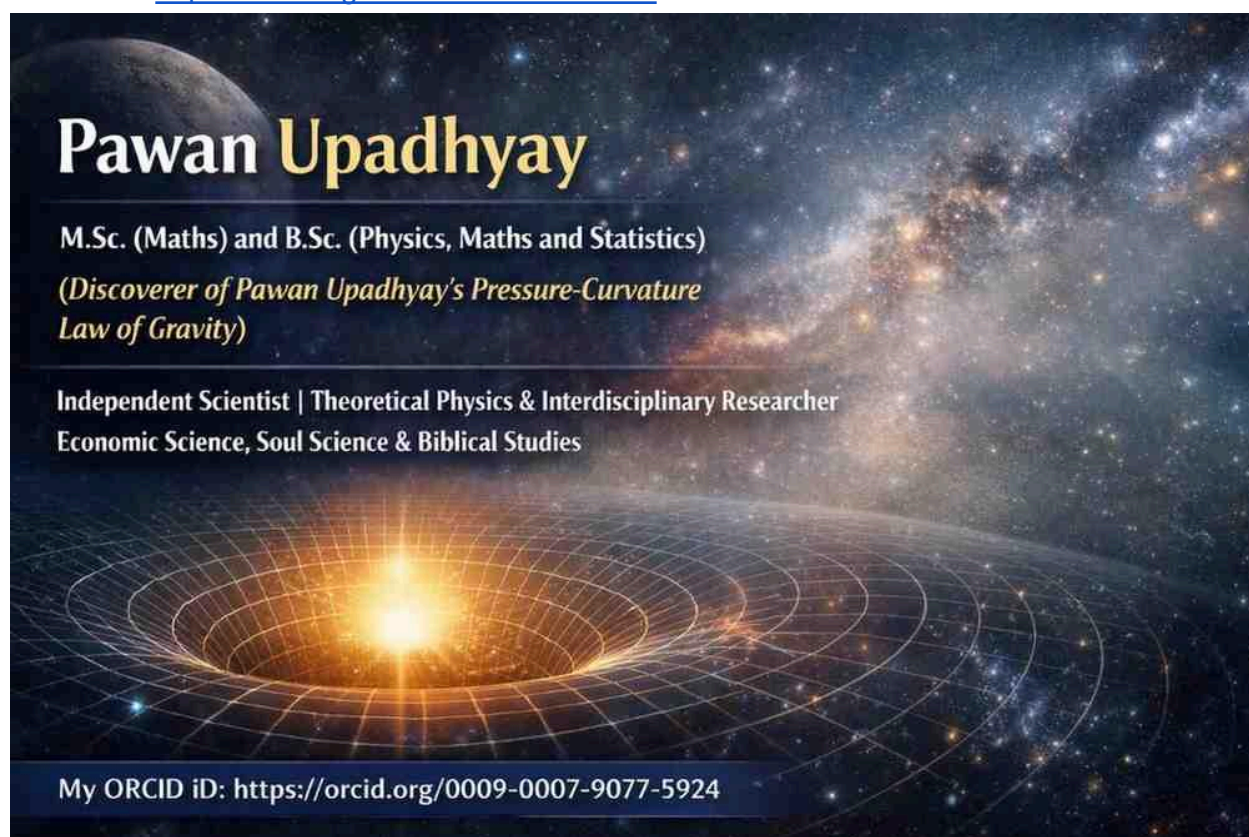
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### Abstract

The doctrine of hell has traditionally been understood within much of Christianity as an eternally continuing state of punishment. This understanding is commonly supported by translating the Greek adjective **αἰώνιος** (*aiōnios*) as “eternal” or “everlasting,” particularly in passages such as Matthew 25:46, where Jesus speaks of “eternal punishment.”

This paper examines whether *aiōnios* necessarily communicates absolute, endless eternity in every context. It argues that **only God possesses absolute eternity and immortality in the unique sense belonging to the Creator**. Hell, by contrast, is presented in Scripture as a created or prepared reality associated with divine judgment.

The paper adopts “**long-age**” as its interpretive translation of *aiōnios* in the judgment passages. This does not claim that *aiōnios* can never be translated “eternal.” The New Testament itself applies *aiōnios* to God, Christ, the Spirit, salvation, and life. Rather, the argument is that the word's meaning must be determined contextually and that its use in relation to God cannot automatically establish that every created reality described by *aiōnios* possesses God's absolute eternity.

The study particularly examines Matthew 25:41, Matthew 25:46, Romans 16:26, 1 Timothy 1:17, 1 Timothy 6:16, Hebrews 9:14, Revelation 20:10–15, and related passages.

The central thesis is:

**God alone is absolutely eternal. Hell is a created instrument of divine judgment. The *aiōnios* character of judgment is therefore best understood in this study as “long-age,” rather than automatically as absolute, endless eternity.**

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# 1. Introduction

The doctrine of hell has been one of the most debated subjects in Christian theology.

For many centuries, the dominant interpretation has understood hell as a state of punishment that continues forever without end. This interpretation is often connected to Jesus' statement in Matthew 25:46:

“These will go away into eternal punishment, but the righteous into eternal life.”

The Greek adjective translated “eternal” is:

**αἰώνιος — *aiōnios***

The question of this paper is therefore not whether the Bible teaches divine judgment.

It clearly does.

The question is:

**Does *aiōnios* necessarily mean absolute, endless existence whenever it appears in a passage concerning judgment?**

This question must be considered together with another foundational biblical truth:

**God alone possesses immortality.**

Paul writes in 1 Timothy 6:16 that God is the one “who alone has immortality.”

If God alone possesses immortality, then no created being can possess immortality independently of God.

This has significant implications for the doctrine of Satan, demons, humanity, and hell.

The devil is not eternal.

Demons are not eternal.

Human beings are not inherently eternal.

Hell is not God.

Hell is not an uncreated principle.

Therefore, the doctrine of hell must be understood within the distinction between **Creator and creation**.

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## 2. The Central Thesis

The thesis of this paper can be stated in four propositions:

### Proposition 1

**God alone is absolutely eternal.**

God has no beginning and no end.

### Proposition 2

**Hell belongs to God's created order and serves a purpose of judgment.**

Jesus describes the fire as having been prepared for the devil and his angels.

### Proposition 3

**The Greek adjective *aiōnios* is related to *aiōn* and has an age-related semantic field.**

It should therefore not automatically be equated with the philosophical concept of absolute endlessness in every context.

#### **Proposition 4**

**In the judgment passages examined here, *aiōnios* is best represented as “long-age.”**

Thus:

**aiōnios fire → long-age fire**

**aiōnios punishment → long-age punishment**

This is the interpretive position of this paper.

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### **3. What Does “Eternal” Mean?**

The English word **eternal** can be used in different senses.

It may mean:

1. without beginning or end;
2. without end;
3. everlasting;
4. belonging to an age;
5. continuing for an indefinitely long period.

These meanings should not be treated as automatically identical.

In this paper, **absolute eternity** means:

**existence without beginning, without end, and independent of creation.**

Under that definition, God alone possesses absolute eternity.

Everything created has an origin.

Consequently, created realities cannot be identified with God's own absolute existence.

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## 4. God Alone Has Immortality

The most important text for establishing the uniqueness of God's immortality is **1 Timothy 6:16**.

Paul describes God as the one:

“who alone has immortality.”

This statement establishes an important theological principle.

If God **alone** possesses immortality, then immortality cannot be an inherent possession of created beings.

Satan does not possess independent immortality.

Demons do not possess independent immortality.

Human beings do not possess independent immortality.

Hell does not possess independent immortality.

Whatever existence creation possesses ultimately depends upon God.

Therefore, the phrase “**eternal hell**” must be examined carefully.

If “eternal” means absolute self-existent immortality, then hell cannot possess that quality.

Only God does.

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## 5. God and *Aiōnios*

At this point an important objection must be addressed.

The New Testament does use **αἰώνιος** (*aiōnios*) in descriptions relating to God.

This evidence is important and must not be ignored.

For example, Romans 16:26 refers to:

**θεοῦ αἰωνίου**

*theou aiōniou*

traditionally:

“the eternal God.”

Therefore, it would be incorrect to claim:

“*Aiōnios* never means eternal.”

The New Testament clearly uses the word in a context describing God.

The question must therefore be more precise:

**Does *aiōnios* have to mean exactly the same metaphysical duration whenever it modifies a different noun?**

The answer of this paper is **no**.

The word must be interpreted according to context.

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## 6. The Eternal God — Romans 16:26

Romans 16:26 contains the expression:

**θεοῦ αἰωνίου**

*theou aiōniou*

Literally:

God *aiōnios*

Traditionally:

eternal God.

Why can *aiōnios* describe God?

Because God truly is eternal.

God is not a created being.

God has no beginning.

God has no end.

Therefore, the theological reality described by *aiōnios* in this context is consistent with God's absolute eternity.

But this does not establish the reverse proposition:

“Everything described by *aiōnios* must therefore be absolutely eternal.”

That would be a logical error.

The meaning of an adjective must be understood with the noun and context.

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## 7. The King of the Ages — 1 Timothy 1:17

An especially significant passage appears in **1 Timothy 1:17**.

Paul describes God as:

**τῷ βασιλεῖ τῶν αἰώνων**

*tō basilei tōn aiōnōn*

Traditionally:

“the eternal King”

But literally the expression contains the plural noun:

**αἰώνων — aiōnōn**

meaning:

**ages**

Thus the expression can be represented:

**King of the ages**

This is theologically profound.

God is not merely associated with one age.

He is sovereign over the ages.

God is the Creator and ruler of the ages.

Therefore, the biblical concept of God and the ages is closely connected.

This provides an important framework for understanding *aiōnios*.

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## 8. *Aiōn* and *Aiōnios*

The noun:

**αἰών — *aiōn***

can refer to an age, epoch, or extended period.

The adjective:

**αἰώνιος — *aiōnios***

is related to this word.

Consequently, the semantic relationship deserves serious consideration.

The traditional translation “eternal” may be appropriate in some contexts, particularly when the subject is God or a reality whose endless duration is established by the broader context.

But the adjective itself should not automatically be treated as a mathematical statement:

“This will continue infinitely without termination.”

The present study therefore uses:

**LONG-AGE**

as its interpretive rendering.

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## 9. What “Long-Age” Means

“Long-age” does not mean:

short.

It does not mean:



insignificant.

It does not mean:

imaginary.

It does not mean:

symbolic only.

It means:

**belonging to or extending through a significant age or period associated with God's purposes.**

The expression is intentionally different from the philosophical definition of absolute eternity.

Thus:

**long-age punishment**

can still be severe.

**long-age fire**

can still be real.

**long-age judgment**

can still be terrifying.

The argument concerns the **nature of duration**, not the seriousness of divine judgment.

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## 10. Matthew 25:41 — The Fire Prepared for the Devil

Jesus says:

“Depart from me, you cursed, into the fire prepared for the devil and his angels.”

The word *aiōnios* appears in this verse in the phrase traditionally translated:

“eternal fire.”

Under the thesis of this paper:

### **long-age fire**

The text tells us something more fundamental than the English translation.

The fire is **prepared**.

It has a purpose.

That purpose is judgment.

The fire is specifically associated with:

- the devil,
- his angels,
- divine judgment.

This means hell should not be conceived as an independently existing eternal realm.

It is associated with God's judicial purpose.

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## **11. Satan Is Not Eternal**

This theological point is essential.

Satan is a creature.

Therefore Satan is not eternal in the absolute sense.

He does not exist independently of God.

He does not possess God's immortality.

He is not God's eternal counterpart.

Christian theology should therefore avoid presenting reality as:

God + eternal evil

Instead, Scripture presents:

God + created evil under judgment.

God's ultimate victory over Satan is therefore the victory of the Creator over a created rebel.

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## 12. Matthew 25:46 — Long-Age Punishment

Matthew 25:46 is the principal passage:

“These will go away into eternal punishment, but the righteous into eternal life.”

The Greek adjective is:

**αἰώνιον — *aiōnion***

It occurs with both:

**κόλασιν — punishment**

and

**ζωὴν — life.**

Thus the proposed rendering is:

**long-age punishment**

and

**long-age life.**

This passage must be treated carefully because the same adjective modifies both nouns.

That observation is valid.

However, it does not prove that the adjective itself means:

“absolutely endless in every possible context.”

It establishes that both realities are characterized by *aiōnios*.

The nature of those realities must then be determined from the wider biblical context.

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## 13. Long-Age Punishment

The phrase:

**κόλασιν αἰώνιον**

can be represented as:

**long-age punishment.**

The emphasis is that punishment belongs to the age of judgment.

This does not diminish the warning.

Jesus' teaching remains serious.

The wicked face divine judgment.

The consequences of rebellion against God are real.

But the adjective *aiōnios* does not need to be transformed into a philosophical definition of infinite duration before the doctrine of judgment can be affirmed.

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## 14. Long-Age Life

The same adjective describes life:

**ζωὴ αἰώνιος**

**long-age life**

Here the broader biblical context becomes important.

God is the source of life.

God alone possesses immortality in the absolute sense.

Therefore, the life granted by God is not independent immortality possessed by creatures.

The righteous receive life from God.

This life is associated with the coming age and ultimately derives its permanence from God Himself.

Therefore, “long-age life” does not mean that God's life itself is merely temporary.

God remains absolutely eternal.

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## 15. God's Eternal Nature and Created Life

There is a critical distinction between:

**God's own existence**

and

**life received from God.**

God is eternal by nature.

Created beings live because God gives life.

Therefore, the ultimate permanence of redeemed life depends upon God.

This distinction allows us to recognize both:

**God alone has immortality**

and

**God grants life to His creatures.**

The creature never becomes God.

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## 16. The Problem of an Eternally Existing Evil Realm

If hell is understood as an absolutely eternal realm in which Satan, demons, or human beings continue endlessly under punishment, an important theological question arises:

Does evil then continue forever as a created reality?

If the devil remains alive forever, demons remain alive forever, and evil human beings remain alive forever, then evil has an everlasting existence.

But Scripture's larger story emphasizes the **defeat of evil**.

The final victory belongs to God.

The long-age interpretation therefore provides a theological framework in which:

**evil is judged rather than eternally preserved.**

God does not need evil to continue forever to demonstrate His justice.

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## 17. The Lake of Fire

Revelation presents the imagery of the **lake of fire**.

Revelation 20 describes the devil being cast into the lake of fire and later describes death and Hades being cast into the same lake.

The imagery is one of final judgment.

The important theological point is that the lake of fire is not portrayed as another eternal godlike reality.

It belongs to the final judgment of creation.

The lake of fire therefore represents the decisive triumph of God's judgment over evil.

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## 18. Death and Destruction

The biblical language of judgment also includes:

- death,
- destruction,
- perishing,
- consuming fire,
- condemnation.

These concepts deserve to be examined alongside the traditional doctrine of everlasting conscious torment.

If Scripture repeatedly describes the destiny of evil using language of **death and destruction**, the interpreter must explain how that language relates to a doctrine in which the condemned remain consciously alive forever.

The long-age interpretation takes these words seriously.

It understands judgment as God's decisive action against evil rather than as the preservation of evil consciousness forever.

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## 19. Unquenchable Fire

The New Testament also speaks of **unquenchable fire**.

An important distinction must be made between:

**unquenchable**

and

**endless.**

A fire can be “unquenchable” in the sense that no person can stop it from accomplishing its appointed purpose.

The word does not necessarily answer the separate question:

How long does the fire continue after its purpose has been accomplished?

Therefore:

**unquenchable ≠ automatically infinite.**

The emphasis can be on the certainty and effectiveness of divine judgment.

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## 20. The Fire of Sodom

Jude 7 describes Sodom and Gomorrah as an example concerning judgment and speaks of the punishment of:

“eternal fire.”

The Greek phrase again uses age-related terminology.

This passage is particularly significant because Sodom's historical destruction by fire provides a biblical example of divine judgment.

The language of “eternal fire” therefore deserves examination in light of what actually happened to Sodom.

The example demonstrates that the expression can function as a description of **divinely appointed judgment**, rather than necessarily functioning as a philosophical definition that the physical fire itself must continue burning endlessly.

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## 21. “Forever and Ever”

A complete study must also examine passages containing:

**εἰς τοὺς αἰῶνας τῶν αἰώνων**

*eis tous aiōnas tōn aiōnōn*

This expression is often translated:

“forever and ever.”

Literally, it contains the language of:

**ages of ages.**

This expression is distinct from simply using the adjective *aiōnios*.

Therefore, the two should not be treated as though they were grammatically identical.

A serious study of Revelation 20:10 must therefore analyze:

1. the Greek expression itself;
2. its literary context;
3. apocalyptic symbolism;
4. its relationship to other judgment passages;



5. the destiny of the devil;
  6. the broader biblical doctrine of God's final victory.
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## 22. The Use of *Aiōnios* for God Does Not Destroy the Long-Age Thesis

We can now answer the major linguistic objection.

Yes:

**The New Testament uses *aiōnios* for God.**

Romans 16:26 provides a clear example.

Therefore, it is wrong to argue:

“*Aiōnios* cannot mean eternal because it is used for God.”

That statement should be rejected.

But it is equally problematic to argue:

“Because *aiōnios* can describe God, every occurrence of *aiōnios* must mean absolute endlessness.”

That conclusion does not follow automatically.

Instead:

**The context determines how the age-related adjective functions in each expression.**

When it describes God, the context of God's nature establishes absolute eternity.

When it describes created judgment, the interpreter must determine what kind of duration the context establishes.

This distinction is central to the argument.

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## 23. The Semantic Range of *Aiōnios*

A responsible Greek study must acknowledge that *aiōnios* has a broader semantic range than a single English word.

It can be associated with:

- an age,
- the coming age,
- perpetual duration,
- long duration,
- eternal realities.

Major lexicons and commentaries recognize that the adjective has been interpreted in more than one way. The debate is therefore not invented by this paper.

The question is which sense best fits the relevant passages.

This paper argues that:

**“Long-age” provides a coherent interpretive framework for the judgment passages without denying the reality of divine punishment.**

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## 24. Why “Only God Is Eternal” Matters

The title of this paper is not merely rhetorical.

It establishes the theological foundation for the entire argument.

If God alone is eternal, then the interpreter must distinguish:

**God's nature**

from

**created duration.**

Hell is not God.

Satan is not God.

The devil is not God.

Demons are not God.

Human souls are not God.

Therefore, none can be assumed to possess absolute eternity simply because Scripture speaks of a future state using *aiōnios*.

God remains uniquely eternal.

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## 25. Divine Judgment Does Not Require Eternal Evil

God can demonstrate perfect justice without preserving evil forever.

A judge does not need a crime to continue forever in order for justice to be real.

Likewise, God's victory does not require evil to remain eternally alive.

The biblical hope is ultimately the triumph of righteousness.

Therefore, the long-age interpretation sees divine judgment as having a **purpose** rather than requiring the endless preservation of evil.

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## 26. The Purpose of Hell

Within this theological framework, hell exists for judgment.

Jesus says the fire was prepared for the devil and his angels.

Therefore, hell serves God's judicial purpose.

Its function includes:

- punishment of evil,
- judgment of rebellion,
- demonstration of God's righteousness,
- defeat of Satanic powers,
- final separation from God.

The reality of hell should therefore not be weakened merely because its duration is interpreted as long-age.

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## 27. Hell Is Not an Eternal Kingdom

The traditional image can sometimes unintentionally make hell appear like an everlasting kingdom existing alongside heaven.

But Scripture presents no dualism in which:

God rules heaven forever  
Satan rules hell forever.

Satan does not rule hell.

Hell belongs to God's judgment.

The devil is its object of judgment, not its king.

This is a crucial theological correction.

There is no eternal kingdom of Satan.

There is only God's kingdom.

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## 28. Creator, Creation, and Judgment

The entire argument can be expressed through a simple theological sequence:

**God → Creator**

**Creation → created by God**

**Sin → rebellion within creation**

**Judgment → God's response to evil**

**Hell/fire → instrument or state of judgment**

**Satan and evil powers → objects of judgment**

**Final victory → God's triumph**

This framework prevents hell from being elevated into an independently eternal reality.

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## 29. Response to the Traditional Interpretation

The traditional interpretation has several significant arguments.

### **Argument 1: Matthew 25:46**

The same *aiōnios* describes punishment and life.

**Response:** This demonstrates the same adjective is applied to both, but the lexical question remains whether *aiōnios* itself means absolute endlessness. The nature of each reality must be understood in context.

### **Argument 2: *Aiōnios* describes God.**

**Response:** Correct. Romans 16:26 uses *aiōnios* for God. But this establishes that the word can describe an eternal God; it does not require every occurrence to have an identical metaphysical meaning.

### **Argument 3: Revelation speaks of the devil's torment.**

**Response:** Revelation must be interpreted in its apocalyptic context, including its symbolic imagery and the distinction between *aiōnios* and “ages of ages.”

### **Argument 4: Eternal punishment has been the historic Christian interpretation.**

**Response:** Historical importance deserves respect, but historical consensus does not eliminate the necessity of examining the Greek text and biblical context.

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## 30. A More Precise Translation Philosophy

This paper therefore adopts the following working translations:

| Greek                      | Conventional translation | Proposed interpretive rendering |
|----------------------------|--------------------------|---------------------------------|
| αἰών ( <i>aiōn</i> )       | age / eternity           | <b>age</b>                      |
| αἰώνιος ( <i>aiōnios</i> ) | eternal / everlasting    | <b>long-age</b>                 |
| πῦρ αἰώνιον                | eternal fire             | <b>long-age fire</b>            |
| κόλασις αἰώνιος            | eternal punishment       | <b>long-age punishment</b>      |
| ζωὴ αἰώνιος                | eternal life             | <b>long-age life</b>            |
| θεὸς αἰώνιος               | eternal God              | <b>eternal God</b> in context   |

The final row is deliberately different.

Why?

Because the **context of God's nature** establishes that God's existence is absolutely eternal.

This demonstrates why translation cannot be reduced to a mechanical one-word substitution.

## 31. Theological Model

The model proposed by this paper can be represented as follows:

**God**

**Absolutely eternal**

↓

**Creation**

**Has a beginning**

↓

**Sin and rebellion**

**Created beings rebel against God**

↓

## **Divine judgment**

**God judges evil**

↓

## **Long-age punishment**

**Judgment belonging to the appointed age**

↓

## **Final victory**

**God triumphs over evil**

This model preserves both divine justice and God's unique eternity.

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# **32. The Meaning of the Title**

The title:

## **Hell Is Not Eternal: Only God Is Eternal**

therefore means something precise.

It does not mean:

“There is no hell.”

It does not mean:

“There is no punishment.”

It does not mean:

“Sin has no consequences.”

It means:

**Hell does not possess the absolute, uncreated eternity that belongs uniquely to God.**

Hell is created.

Hell has a purpose.

Hell belongs to divine judgment.

Its *aiōnios* character is understood in this paper as **long-age**.

God alone is absolutely eternal.

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## 33. Conclusion

The doctrine of hell must be examined from both a **linguistic** and a **theological** perspective.

The linguistic evidence demonstrates that **αἰώνιος (*aiōnios*)** is capable of being associated with eternal realities, including God Himself. Romans 16:26 explicitly describes God with *aiōnios*. Therefore, the argument cannot simply be that *aiōnios* never means “eternal.”

However, this does not settle the question of every occurrence of the word.

The New Testament also connects *aiōnios* with the concept of the age, while *aiōn* itself is used for “age” and “ages.” 1 Timothy 1:17 is especially significant because God is described as **King of the ages**.

More importantly, Scripture declares that God **alone possesses immortality**.

This establishes a fundamental theological distinction.

God is the eternal Creator.

Hell is not the Creator.

Satan is not the Creator.

Demons are not the Creator.

Human beings are not the Creator.

Hell is therefore not an independently eternal reality existing alongside God.

Jesus describes the fire as having been **prepared for the devil and his angels**.



The judgment is real.

The punishment is serious.

The fire is significant.

But the *aiōnios* character of this judgment need not automatically be interpreted as absolute, endless existence.

This paper therefore proposes:

**“Long-age punishment” rather than “eternal punishment.”**

**“Long-age fire” rather than “eternal fire.”**

This terminology is intended to preserve the relationship between *aiōn* and *aiōnios* while distinguishing created judgment from God's absolute eternity.

The ultimate Christian confession is therefore not that God and an eternal hell exist forever as two permanent realities.

It is:

**God alone is eternal.**

God is the Creator.

God is the source of immortality.

God is the judge.

God will overcome evil.

And the final word belongs not to an eternally existing kingdom of punishment, but to **the eternal God and His ultimate victory over evil.**

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## **Selected Biblical Texts for Detailed Study**

### **God and immortality**

- 1 Timothy 6:16
- Romans 16:26
- 1 Timothy 1:17
- Hebrews 9:14

## **Hell and judgment**

- Matthew 25:41
- Matthew 25:46
- Mark 9:43–48
- Luke 12:5
- Jude 7
- 2 Thessalonians 1:9

## **Final judgment**

- Revelation 14:9–11
- Revelation 19:20
- Revelation 20:10
- Revelation 20:14–15
- Revelation 21:1–4

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## **Final Statement**

**HELL IS NOT GOD.**

**HELL IS NOT UNCREATED.**

**HELL IS NOT AN ETERNAL KINGDOM OF EVIL.**

**HELL IS A REALITY OF DIVINE JUDGMENT.**

**THE *AIŌNIOS* JUDGMENT IS UNDERSTOOD HERE AS LONG-AGE JUDGMENT.**

**ONLY GOD IS ABSOLUTELY ETERNAL.**

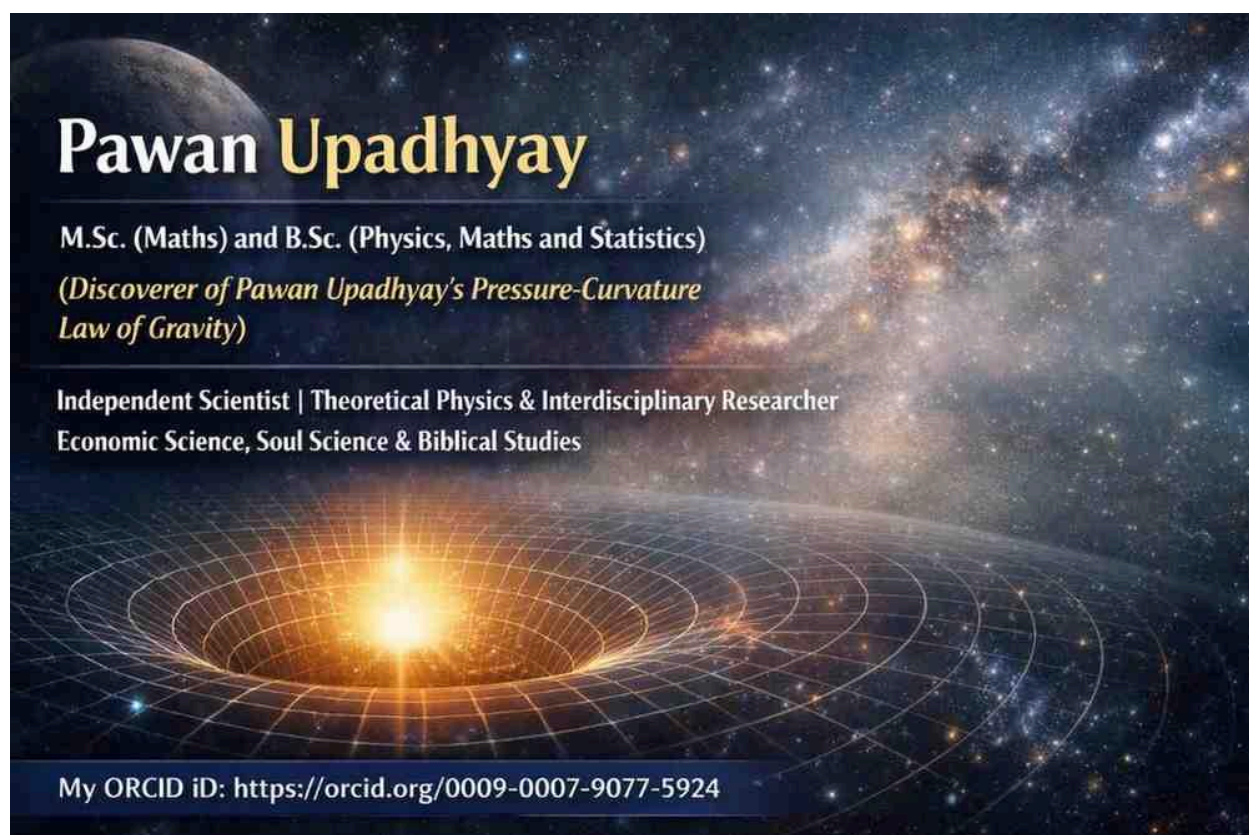
**ONLY GOD HAS IMMORTALITY IN HIMSELF.**

**AND GOD'S FINAL PURPOSE IS THE TRIUMPH OF GOOD OVER EVIL.**

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**[Blog Version]**

# **Hell Is Not Eternal: Understanding *Aiōnios* as Long-Age Judgment**



The traditional Christian doctrine of hell often describes hell as **eternal conscious torment without end**. But there is an important question that deserves careful examination:

**Does the Greek word αἰώνιος (*aiōnios*) necessarily mean “eternal” in the absolute sense of having no beginning and no end?**

This article argues that *aiōnios* should be understood as “**long-age**” or “**belonging to the age**” in the judgment passages under discussion. This does not deny divine judgment. Rather, it distinguishes the **eternality of God** from the **duration of a created judgment**.

**Central thesis:** God alone possesses absolute eternality. Hell is created by God for judgment and punishment. Therefore, the *aiōnios* character of hell should be understood as **long-age judgment**, rather than automatically equating hell with the infinite, uncreated existence of God.

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## 1. Only God Is Eternal in the Absolute Sense

God is fundamentally different from everything He has created.

God did not come into existence. God has no beginning and no end. He is the Creator, while everything else belongs to the created order.

Therefore, when we use “**eternal**” in its **absolute philosophical sense**, we are describing something that is:

- without beginning,
- without end,
- not created,
- not dependent upon anything else for existence.

That description properly belongs to **God Himself**.

Hell, however, is not God.

Hell is not self-existent. Hell is not uncreated. Hell exists because God prepared it for judgment.

Jesus says:

“the eternal fire prepared for the devil and his angels”  
— Matthew 25:41

The important point is that the fire is **prepared**. It belongs to God's created order and serves a divine purpose.

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## 2. Hell Is a Created Instrument of Judgment

Jesus specifically connects the fire of judgment with **the devil and his angels**:

**Matthew 25:41**

“Depart from me, you cursed, into the fire ... prepared for the devil and his angels.”

Thus, the biblical picture is not that hell is an independent eternal kingdom existing alongside God.

Rather:

**God → Creator**

**Creation → created by God**

**Judgment → God's act of judgment**

**Fire → prepared for judgment**

**Satan and evil spirits → objects of judgment**

Hell therefore has a **purpose**.

It exists because God created or prepared it for the punishment and judgment of evil.

This distinction is important when discussing *aiōnios*.

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### 3. The Greek Word *Aiōnios*

The Greek adjective is:

**αἰώνιος — aiōnios**

It is related to:

**αἰών — aiōn**

The noun *aiōn* can refer to an **age, an epoch, or an extended period of time**. Consequently, *aiōnios* is connected conceptually with the age.

For the purposes of this theological interpretation, we will translate *aiōnios* as:

#### **LONG-AGE**

rather than automatically translating it as “eternal.”

This gives us expressions such as:

**αἰώνιον πῦρ**

*aiōnion pyr*

→ **long-age fire**

**κόλασιν αἰώνιον**

*kolasin aiōnion*

→ **long-age punishment**

**ζωὴν αἰώνιον**

*zōēn aiōnion*

→ **long-age life**

The Greek form itself does not contain the English philosophical concept “infinite, without beginning and without end.” The meaning must be determined by context.

Even discussions of Matthew 25:46 acknowledge that *aiōnios* has been understood as “age-long” and that the word itself does not necessarily, in every context, establish infinite duration.

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## 4. Matthew 25:46 — Long-Age Punishment

One of the most important passages is Matthew 25:46:

“And these will depart into **eternal punishment**, but the righteous into **eternal life**.”

The Greek contains the same adjective in both expressions:

**κόλασιν αἰώνιον**

*kolasin aiōnion* — punishment *aiōnios*

and

**ζωὴν αἰώνιον**

*zōēn aiōnion* — life *aiōnios*.

Under the traditional translation:

eternal punishment

eternal life

Under the **long-age interpretation**:

**long-age punishment**

**long-age life**

This does not mean that the two expressions have nothing to do with the age to come. They clearly concern the destiny associated with God's judgment and the coming life.

The question is whether *aiōnios* itself establishes **absolute endlessness**.

The argument of this article is:

**No. The word should be understood according to the age and context in which it occurs.**

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## 5. “Long-Age” Does Not Mean “Unimportant”

It is important not to misunderstand this position.

Saying that hell is **long-age** does **not** mean:

- judgment is temporary in a trivial sense;
- sin has no consequences;
- hell is merely symbolic;
- God's judgment should not be feared;
- everyone automatically escapes judgment.

The biblical warnings about judgment are extremely serious.

A long-age punishment can be extraordinarily severe and extensive without requiring us to define it as **absolute, infinite existence**.

The distinction is between:

**severity and duration**

and

**God's absolute eternity.**

---

## 6. The Fire Prepared for the Devil

Jesus says:

“the fire prepared for the devil and his angels.”

This is significant because the purpose of the fire is judgment against spiritual evil.

The biblical narrative presents Satan, the devil, demons, and evil powers as enemies of God whose ultimate defeat is certain.

Therefore, hell should be understood primarily as part of **God's victory over evil**, rather than as an independently existing eternal realm.

God remains sovereign.

Evil does not become an eternal counterpart to God.

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## 7. Satan, Devils, and Evil Spirits

Your theological position can therefore be expressed as follows:

**God created judgment for evil spiritual beings.**

Satan is not God's eternal opposite.

The devil is a creature.

Demons are creatures.

Evil spirits are creatures.

They therefore do not possess God's absolute eternity.

Their existence and destiny remain under God's authority.

This is important because a doctrine of endlessly existing evil can raise a theological question:

**Would evil itself continue forever as an eternal reality?**

The long-age interpretation answers:

**No. Evil is ultimately subjected to God's judgment and defeated.**

God alone remains absolutely eternal.

---

## 8. The Meaning of “Eternal Fire”

Matthew 25:41 uses:

**πῦρ τὸ αἰώνιον**  
*pyr to aiōnion*

Traditionally:

eternal fire



Our proposed translation:

### **long-age fire**

The adjective describes the fire in relation to the *aiōn*.

This does not mean the fire is weak or metaphorical.

It means its **duration and function belong to the age of judgment**.

The distinction is important:

**Long-age does not mean imaginary.**

Fire can represent genuine divine judgment while *aiōnios* describes its age-related duration.

---

## **9. “Forever and Ever” Requires Separate Examination**

Some passages use a different expression:

**εἰς τοὺς αἰῶνας τῶν αἰώνων**

*eis tous aiōnas tōn aiōnōn*

Literally, this involves:

“unto the ages of the ages.”

This expression deserves a separate study because it is not simply identical to the adjective *aiōnios*.

Therefore, we should not automatically assume that every occurrence of:

**αἰώνιος**

means exactly the same thing as:

**εἰς τοὺς αἰῶνας τῶν αἰώνων.**

A careful study must distinguish the different Greek constructions.

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## 10. “Eternal” Does Not Always Mean the Same Thing

The English word **eternal** can carry an absolute philosophical meaning:

having no beginning and no end.

But biblical language can use time-related terminology in ways that are more contextual.

For example, Scripture can speak about things associated with an age, an ancient period, or an established order.

This is why translating every occurrence of *aiōnios* as “eternal” and then defining “eternal” as “absolutely endless” can potentially introduce an interpretation that is stronger than the Greek adjective itself.

Even traditional commentary acknowledges that the precise meaning and duration expressed by *aiōnios* have been debated, including the possibility of an “age-long” or indefinite duration.

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## 11. But What About Eternal Life?

This is the strongest objection to the long-age interpretation.

Matthew 25:46 uses the same adjective:

**long-age punishment**

and

**long-age life**

Someone may therefore ask:

**“If punishment is not endless, why should life be endless?”**

This is an important question.

The answer proposed here is that the adjective itself establishes the **age-related character** of the reality, while the **nature of the thing being described** determines its ultimate significance.

God's life is inherently without end because God is eternal.

Life received from God ultimately participates in God's immortal life.

Punishment, however, concerns a created process of judgment.

Therefore, *aiōnios* does not have to impose exactly the same metaphysical duration upon every noun it modifies.

The context remains essential.

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## 12. God Is Not *Aiōnios* in the Same Sense as Hell

This is perhaps the most important theological distinction.

If Scripture describes God as *aiōnios*, that does not mean God merely exists for “a long age.”

God's existence is fundamentally different.

God is the **Creator of the ages**.

God does not derive His existence from an age.

An age derives its existence from God.

Therefore:

**God → transcends creation**

while:

**Hell → belongs to creation.**

Consequently, we should not make the created realm equal to the Creator simply because the same adjective can sometimes be associated with both.

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## 13. Hell Has a Divine Purpose

Hell is not presented merely as a place where God abandons His creation.

It is associated with:

- judgment,
- punishment,
- fire,
- destruction,
- condemnation,
- the defeat of evil.

The purpose is God's righteous judgment.

The long-age interpretation therefore maintains the seriousness of biblical judgment while rejecting the necessity of defining hell as an **absolutely eternal created realm**.

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## 14. The Difference Between “Long-Age” and “Temporary”

A common misunderstanding would be:

“If hell is not eternal, then it must be temporary and therefore insignificant.”

That does not follow.

Consider the difference:

**Temporary** can suggest something brief or insignificant.

**Long-age** describes something associated with a substantial age or extended period.

The proposed interpretation is not:

“Hell lasts for a few moments.”

It is:

**Hell is a long-age judgment belonging to God's appointed age of punishment.**

Its exact duration cannot simply be calculated from the adjective *aiōnios* alone.

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## 15. The Biblical Warning Remains Serious

Jesus did not present judgment as something to ignore.

His warnings about Gehenna, fire, judgment, and punishment were intended to produce repentance.

Therefore, even if *aiōnios* is understood as **long-age**, the doctrine should never be turned into:

“It does not matter what we do.”

Quite the opposite.

The message remains:

**Sin has consequences.**

**God judges evil.**

**Judgment is real.**

**The consequences are severe.**

**Satan and evil powers will be defeated.**

**God's righteousness will ultimately prevail.**

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## 16. The Final Victory Belongs to God

The central theological principle is therefore not:

“Hell is eternal.”

The deeper biblical principle is:

**God is eternal, and God ultimately defeats evil.**

God does not need an eternally existing hell in order to remain just.

Nor does God need evil to continue endlessly in order for His judgment to be meaningful.

God is the beginning and the end.

Creation belongs to Him.

Judgment belongs to Him.

The defeat of evil belongs to Him.

And ultimately, **God alone possesses absolute eternity.**

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## 17. A Summary of the Long-Age Interpretation

The argument can be summarized in seven propositions:

### 1. God alone is absolutely eternal.

God has no beginning and no end.

### 2. Hell is created or prepared by God.

Jesus describes the fire as prepared for the devil and his angels.

### 3. Therefore, hell is not God.

Hell cannot be identified with God's own absolute eternity.

### 4. *Aiōnios* is connected with *aiōn*.

The word can be understood in an age-related sense.

### 5. In the judgment passages, we use “long-age.”

Thus:

**aiōnios fire → long-age fire**

**aiōnios punishment → long-age punishment**

### 6. Long-age does not mean insignificant.

Divine judgment remains real and severe.

### 7. God's final victory is greater than the continuation of evil.

The ultimate hope is not eternal coexistence between God and evil, but the triumph of God's righteousness.

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## Conclusion

**Hell is not eternal in the same absolute sense that God is eternal.**

God alone is without beginning and without end. Hell belongs to the created order and exists because God prepared it for judgment.

The Greek word **αἰώνιος** (*aiōnios*), traditionally translated “eternal” or “everlasting,” is connected with **αἰών** (*aiōn*), the concept of an age. In the interpretation presented here, *aiōnios* in the judgment passages is therefore understood as **long-age**.

Consequently:

**long-age fire**  
**long-age punishment**  
**long-age judgment**

These expressions describe the serious judgment associated with the age to come without requiring us to make hell an absolutely eternal reality independent of God's purposes.

The essential distinction is simple:

**God is eternal.**

**Hell is created.**

**God is without beginning and without end.**

**Hell has an appointed purpose and duration.**

**God judges Satan, the devil, evil spirits, and those who persist in evil.**

**God ultimately triumphs over evil.**

Therefore, the doctrine of **long-age punishment** preserves the biblical seriousness of divine judgment while maintaining the unique and absolute eternity of God.